THE GERMANS

Germanic tribes and federations – Teutones, Alamanni, Goths, Franks, Vandals, and many others – were among the most determined and persistent enemies of the Roman Empire from the 2nd century BCE to the 5th century CE. Like the Celts, the Germans were used to more or less permanent tribal warfare, often practised by warbands of young men led by an experienced fighter of noted prowess. Their battlefield tactics seem to have differed from the Celts in so far as they involved a more compact formation and a larger measure of coordination. According to Julius Caesar, writing in the 1st century BCE, they fought in a tight infantry phalanx, armed with iron-tipped spears.

> "THEY THINK IT TAME AND STUPID ... TO ACQUIRE BY THE SWEAT OF TOIL WHAT THEY MIGHT WIN BY THEIR BLOOD."
>
> **TACITUS** DESCRIBING THE CHARACTER OF THE GERMANIC PEOPLES, 1ST CENTURY CE



Germans defeated
Made in around 250 CE, this relief on the Ludovisi sarcophagus shows clean-shaven Romans triumphing over hirsute bearded Germanic warriors.

The Germans were also adept at avoiding pitched battles, using ambushes and harassing hit-and-run tactics. It was in this way that they weakened and eventually destroyed the Roman legions led by Varus at the Teutoburger Wald in 9 CE. Over time cavalry became an important part of Germanic forces. Horsemen on short sturdy mounts rode forward armed with shield and javelin, accompanied by swiftly running foot soldiers similarly armed. Among the Ostrogoths and the Vandals there evolved an armoured horse-riding aristocracy that pointed forward to the medieval knight.

Many German tribes found employment as Roman auxiliaries and, by the 4th century CE, had a dominant position in the forces of the later Western Empire. The Goths who sacked the city of Rome in 410 CE had been part of the Roman army, and it was Gothic and other German chiefs who ruled the successor states when the Western Empire finally disintegrated.

THE CELTS

The Celts of western Europe – Gauls, Iberians, Britons – had a distinctive style of warfare that contrasted strikingly with that of the Romans. Bands of young men, following a leader of acknowledged strength and courage, would regularly embark on raids on neighbouring peoples. Tribal battles were probably heavily formalized, with individual warriors first stepping forward to proclaim their prowess and challenge enemies to single combat.

An attack involved a wild charge accompanied by a cacophony of noise. Although some Roman historians describe the Celts as fighting naked, they mostly wore a tunic and trousers. Elite warriors would have worn a helmet and even chainmail or leather armour, although shields were their main defence. Mostly fighting on foot, they wielded long slashing swords and short spears. Some Celtic peoples employed war chariots to disrupt the enemy formation.



CELTIC HORNED HELMET

The Romans first encountered the Celts when the latter invaded Italy in the 4th century BCE, and subsequently fought them on many occasions, most notably in the campaign against the Gauls under Vercingetorix in 52 BCE and the suppression of the Iceni revolt led by Boudicca in Britain in 60–61 CE. The Romans were impressed by the Celts' physical strength – they are described as tall, with rippling muscles – and by their wild courage in battle.

> "WEIRD, DISCORDANT HORNS WERE SOUNDED ... THEY BEAT THEIR SWORDS RHYTHMICALLY AGAINST THEIR SHIELDS."
>
> **DIODORUS SICULUS** DESCRIBING CELTS IN BATTLE, 1ST CENTURY BCE



Ceremonial shield
Made of bronze with studs of coloured glass, this shield once belonged to an elite Celtic warrior in Britain. Dating from the 2nd century BCE, it was probably intended for ceremonial use rather than for combat.